

THE LAST PROTEST IN THE AMU CAMPUS WAS STAGED FOLLOWING THE DEATH OF SHAHNAWAZ ALAM



Zero Tolerance ZONE

A student's suspension for protesting against an autocratic administration proves that freedom of expression is an idea whose time is yet to come at AMU

By Farzand Ahmed

War is peace, freedom is slavery and ignorance is bliss." For Mohammad Adil Hossain, 23, these are not merely lines from George Orwell's 1984, but a reality he's part of as a student of mass communication at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU). Last week, Hossain was suspended for using the Internet in the campus to "depict the entire institutional infrastructure and administrative apparatus in poor light".

Hossain had been one of the most trenchant critics of Vice-Chancellor (vc) P.K. Abdul Azis' attempts to put

the student-teacher community in AMU under surveillance through CCTV cameras and local intelligence units (LIU) across the campus. He used his classroom as a forum to highlight the vc's dictatorial ways that is increasingly impinging on the privacy of students and teachers alike.

If this wasn't enough, Hossain was also one of the first students to be openly critical of the authorities who "suspended a reader of Marathi literature, Shrinivas Ramchandra Siras, for his alleged misconduct—having sex with another man in his university quarters," he wrote in his university's newsletter where he gathered views from students on the matter. No one

missed his criticism when he went on to question the university authorities, saying, "The incident was exposed through a dubious sting operation. What about respecting one's privacy? How is the university justified in taking action against someone by breaching his privacy through an illegal sting operation?" Hossain went on to expose corruption in high places by using the Right to Information (RTI) Act and circulating the responses through the Internet and an online group of former students, teachers and intellectuals called The Aligarh Forum.

This is the second time that Hossain is facing the vc's wrath. Last year, he was suspended for partici-